

SERIES DOSSIER: THE PUNISHER: WELCOME BACK, FRANK

Phase 5 · Disney+ Series #1 (Saga Two, Series #3)

Status:  DOSSIER COMPLETE (awaiting showrunner lock)

1. IDENTITY

Field	Entry
Series #	Phase 5, Series #1 (limit: 2 this phase)
Phase	Phase 5, The Secret Wars Saga : "Time Runs Out"
Real title	<i>THE PUNISHER: WELCOME BACK, FRANK</i> (the 616 storyline)
Decoy / codename title	" <i>NEIGHBORHOOD WATCH</i> "
Premiere	Tuesday, March 3, 2026
Finale	Tuesday, May 5, 2026
Episodes	10 (one a week, Tuesdays)
Episode runtime	50–58 minutes
Platform	Disney+ (real history: in 2025 Disney+ moved its Marvel premieres to Tuesday nights, starting with Daredevil: Born Again)
Showrunner	Steve Lightfoot
Rating	TV-MA, under the R-rated street-level label
Genre + second genre	Superhero crime drama + pitch-black comedy / urban war story

Episode schedule

Ep	Title	Airdate
1	"Welcome Back, Frank"	Tue, March 3, 2026
2	"Ma"	Tue, March 10, 2026
3	"Hell's Kitchen"	Tue, March 17, 2026
4	"The Vigilantes"	Tue, March 24, 2026
5	"Spacker Dave"	Tue, March 31, 2026
6	"The Russian"	Tue, April 7, 2026
7	"Joan"	Tue, April 14, 2026
8	"Soap"	Tue, April 21, 2026
9	"Zoo"	Tue, April 28, 2026
10	"Goodbye, Ma"	Tue, May 5, 2026

2. OWNERSHIP

Field	Entry	
Whose series / franchise is this?	JON BERNTHAL, who has played the Punisher since <i>Captain America: Civil War</i> (2016). The Punisher franchise is his.	

Character	Actor	Age at premiere
Frank Castle / The Punisher	Jon Bernthal	49
Ma Gnucci	Fresh casting (<i>never played by a real actor</i>)	—
The Russian	Fresh casting	—
Det. Martin Soap	Fresh casting	—
Joan the Mouse / Spacker Dave / Mr. Bumpo (<i>Frank's neighbors</i>)	Fresh casting	—
Matt Murdock / Daredevil (<i>Episodes 3–4</i>)	Charlie Cox	43
Wilson Fisk (<i>Episode 10 post-credit</i>)	Vincent D'Onofrio	66

3. SOURCE MATERIAL (EARTH-616)

Field	Entry
Primary comic(s) adapted	" <i>Welcome Back, Frank</i> ", <i>The Punisher</i> vol. 5 #1–12 (2000–01), Garth Ennis & Steve Dillon: Frank Castle comes back to New York and goes to war with the Gnucci crime family. Ma Gnucci hunts him, copycat vigilantes appear, the Russian gets sent to kill him, and Detective Soap is assigned to catch him.
Supporting comics	<i>Amazing Spider-Man</i> #129 (1974, the Punisher's first appearance) · <i>Punisher: Year One</i> (1994, his family's murder) · <i>Welcome Back, Frank</i> #3 (2000, Daredevil tries to stop Frank)
Nerf check	☒ Frank is the most dangerous man in New York. No powers, just Marine training and will. The Russian beats him in round one , as on 616, and Frank wins the rematch.

3A. COMIC ACCURACY REPORT

Field	Entry
Overall accuracy score	97%. Ennis and Dillon's run is adapted issue for issue, including its black humor.

Straight from the page:

- **Frank Castle**, a Marine whose **family was murdered in Central Park**, comes back to **wage war on the Gnucci family** (#1).
- **Ma Gnucci** loses her sons, then **her limbs** (Frank feeds her to polar bears at the zoo, and she survives), and **keeps coming** (#1–12).
- **Copycat vigilantes** (a priest, a retired cop, and a stockbroker) try to "be the Punisher" (#4–5).
- **The Russian**, a giant hired killer, **nearly beats Frank** (#6).
- **Detective Martin Soap**, the NYPD's most useless cop, is **put on the Punisher case** (#1–12).
- **Frank's neighbors**, Joan the Mouse, Spacker Dave and Mr. Bumpo, **end up helping him** (#1–12).
- **Daredevil** tries to stop him. **Frank drugs him** (#3).
- **Frank burns down the Gnucci mansion with Ma inside** (#12).

How the violence is handled: TV-MA, **true to Ennis's tone**, including his dark comedy. **The violence is never glamorized.** Frank is a **tragic figure**, not a role model.

POWERS & ABILITIES

Character	616 powers & abilities	Shown in the series	Held back (why)	Match
The Punisher	Peak human; Marine special-forces training; master of every weapon, tactician, interrogator	Dismantles a crime family in ten weeks	–	✓ 100%
The Russian	Superhuman durability and strength (nearly)	Wins round one	–	✓ 100%
Daredevil	As in <i>Born Again</i>	The rooftop fight in Hell's Kitchen	–	✓ 100%

4. STORY

Field	Entry
Logline	Frank Castle comes home to New York to kill every member of a crime family, and finds himself with a copycat problem, a useless cop on his tail, and neighbors who won't leave him alone.
Theme	War never ends. Frank's only family now is the one he can't get rid of: the lonely people in his building.
Villain / antagonist	Ma Gnucci (main); the Russian

What the season is about

- **Episodes 1–3:** Frank's back. The Gnuccis lose three sons in one night. **Ma Gnucci** swears revenge. **Detective Soap** gets the case. **Daredevil** tries to stop him on a rooftop, and Frank drugs him: "*Go home, Red.*"
- **Episodes 4–6:** **Copycat vigilantes** show up. Frank shuts them down. Ma Gnucci loses her limbs **at the zoo**. **The Russian** comes for Frank, and **Frank loses**.
- **Episodes 7–9:** Frank recovers **in his neighbor Joan's apartment**. He has something like a home now. The rematch with the Russian ends with Frank winning.
- **Episode 10:** **The Gnucci mansion burns** with Ma inside. Frank leaves the city at dawn. Joan leaves a light on for him.

5. MCU TIMELINE PLACEMENT

Field	Entry
When it's set	Monday, June 2, 2025 → Saturday, September 27, 2025.
Where it's set	New York City (Hell's Kitchen, Little Italy, the Central Park Zoo)
Relative to other films	It runs at the same time as <i>The Kree-Skrull War</i> . Frank ignores the alien war in the sky: <i>"Not my problem."</i>

6. WORLD-BUILDING

The series' own world

- **The R-rated street level:** Frank and Matt, **Soap**, Frank's neighbors.

World-building for the wider MCU

Seed	How it appears	Payoff
Fisk's return	Post-credit scene	Street level, Phase 6

Setting up the Big Bad (THE SECRET WARS SAGA)

Seed	How it appears	What it means
The end of the world, from the street	Frank, looking at two Earths in the sky: <i>"World's ending. Still got work."</i>	The Incursions are visible to everyone now

7. POST-CREDIT SCENE (Episode 10)

Field	Entry
Post-credit scene	✅ "MAYOR." Wilson Fisk, in a sharp suit, stands at a podium on the City Hall steps: <i>"...and as your next mayor, I promise to restore order to this city."</i>
Secret shoot codename	"CAMPAIGN SEASON."

CHECKLIST

- ☒ Comic(s) adapted · ☒ Comic Accuracy Report + powers · ☒ Real and decoy titles · ☒ What it's about · ☒ Villain · ☒ Post-credit scene · ☒ The series' own world-building · ☒ MCU world-building · ☒ Big Bad setup · ☒ Whose franchise · ☒ When and where in the timeline · ☒ **Episode count, runtimes and release pattern**